SPORTS

ASIAN GAMES 2026

Chasing a Golden Dream

Most Indian athletes headed for Aichi-Nagoya aspire to a glory night on the podium. Here are seven of India's brightest medal prospects, going by their current form

By Suhani Singh



MUJEEB FARUQUI

Aichi-Nagoya 2026 in Japan will be significant not only for the opportunity it will offer Indian athletes to chase personal glory, but also because a strong showing will strengthen India's case to host its maiden Olympics in 2036 and its third Asian Games in 2038. The competition is likely to be on par with, if not tougher than, the Commonwealth Games held less than two months ago, particularly in badminton, table tennis, wrestling, shooting, judo, archery, boxing, esports and weightlifting, where some of the world's best athletes will be in action. Hopes are especially high for the large shooting and wrestling contingents, while rowing is also expected to bring home a few medals.

India will field 503 athletes across 36 disciplines. In the team events, the men's and women's kabaddi teams, both favourites, will look to defend their titles, though Iran is expected to provide stiff competition. The men's and women's hockey teams, back in their iconic blue jerseys, know that gold will secure a ticket to the Los Angeles Games in 2028. Also in the spotlight will be the men's volleyball and women's rugby teams, both chasing historic podium finishes. In badminton, 2024 men's doubles gold medallists Chirag Shetty and Satwiksairaj Rankireddy will have their work cut out in the team and doubles events.

Gen Z is out in force too. Surfing makes its debut, with four young Indian surfers—Kamali Moorthy, 16; Sivaraj Babu, 23; Kishore Kumar, 18; and Sugar Shanti Banarse, 21—taking to the waves at Akabane Long Beach. Fifteen gamers will compete against some of the world's best esports athletes across four events—Pokémon Unite, eFootball, League of Legends and Puyo Puyo Champions. Meanwhile, junior world squash champion Anahat Singh, 19, will look to better the bronze she won at the last edition.

On the following pages are profiles of some of India's brightest medal prospects. Their performances will be crucial if India is to achieve its ambitious target of finishing among the top three in the medal tally. ■

NEXT BIG SHOT

ESHA SINGH, 21

Sport: *SHOOTING*

Discipline: 10m pistol and 25m rapidfire pistol

Claim to fame

25m gold at the ISSF World Cups in Hangzhou and Munich (world record) in 2026, 10m gold at Asian Championships, New Delhi, 2026